# Receiving benefits without shame

Chronic conditions, changing circumstances and the support you may need.

## When earning a living becomes difficult

Living with a chronic condition can change how much work you can manage, or mean you cannot work at all. Needing benefits to pay for food, bills or everyday essentials can bring grief, worry or a loss of independence. You may miss your job, your routine or the identity that came with earning a wage. Those feelings deserve understanding.

## Needing help is not a personal failure

Claiming support you qualify for is not an admission that you have failed. Illness and disability can affect people at any stage of life. Your worth is not measured by your wages, your working hours or whether you can work. You do not have to apologise for needing enough money to live.

## The judgement from other people

Comments such as “You’re getting something for nothing”, “You look well enough to work” or “I wish I could stay at home” can be hurtful. Someone may see a short outing or a better day without seeing the pain, exhaustion, appointments or recovery afterwards. Being on benefits does not mean someone is lazy, dishonest or living an easy life.

## Benefits are not all the same

Some benefits help with low income; others help with the extra costs of disability or support people whose health affects work. Some can be paid while someone is working. For example, Personal Independence Payment (PIP) can be paid to eligible people who work or have savings. Receiving benefits does not always mean being unable to earn a wage. [1]

## You can choose what you share

You can say, “My health affects what I can manage, and I receive support I qualify for.” You can also say, “I would rather keep my finances private.” You do not owe friends, neighbours or strangers your medical or financial history. Official benefit applications do need accurate information and any required changes must be reported.

## You deserve dignity, whether you work, receive benefits, or do both.

# Which benefits might help?

An introduction for adults in England. This is not a full eligibility check.

## Personal Independence Payment (PIP) [1]

Helps with extra living costs where a long-term condition or disability causes difficulties with specified everyday activities or getting around. It has daily living and mobility parts. It is not based on income or savings, and you can receive it while working. New claims are usually for people aged 16 to under State Pension age. A diagnosis alone does not decide entitlement.

## Universal Credit (UC) [2]

May help with living costs if your household has a low income, including if you work. Your and your partner’s income and savings can affect entitlement. Report a health condition that affects work and provide fit notes if required. An assessment may be needed; some people qualify for an additional health-related amount. This is separate from a PIP assessment.

## New Style Employment and Support Allowance [3]

New Style ESA may help if illness or disability limits your ability to work and you meet the National Insurance contribution conditions. Savings and a partner’s earnings do not normally affect it, although some pension income can. It can sometimes be paid with UC, but UC is reduced by the amount of New Style ESA paid. Get a check of the combined position.

## Attendance Allowance [4]

For eligible people at State Pension age or over who need personal help or supervision because of a disability or health condition. You can qualify even if nobody is currently giving you that help. It is not means-tested, so income and savings do not determine the award. It does not include a mobility component. Do not assume you should switch from an existing disability benefit when you reach pension age.

## If you live elsewhere in the UK [5]

Scotland uses Adult Disability Payment and Pension Age Disability Payment for the corresponding adult disability support. In Wales and Northern Ireland, check the appropriate official guidance and claim routes. Other help and local schemes vary too. Use mygov.scot for Scotland, nidirect.gov.uk for Northern Ireland, and GOV.UK and your council for England and Wales.

# Other financial help to check

A benefits check can also uncover help with everyday costs.

## Sick pay and support with work [6]

If you are employed, check your employer's sick-pay policy and whether you qualify for Statutory Sick Pay. Access to Work may help eligible people get or stay in paid work through practical support, equipment or travel assistance. It does not replace the reasonable adjustments an employer must make.

## Rent, Council Tax and adaptations [7]

Depending on your circumstances, help with rent may be available through UC or Housing Benefit. Council Tax Reduction is a separate council application; do not assume it happens automatically. A different scheme, the Disabled Band Reduction, may apply if your home has qualifying disability-related features. Ask your council about essential home adaptations and whether a Disabled Facilities Grant could help.

## Prescriptions, dental care and other NHS costs [8]

Check NHS help with health costs or the NHS Low Income Scheme. PIP and New Style ESA do not by themselves give automatic entitlement to free NHS prescriptions or dental treatment. UC entitlement depends on additional rules. Prescription charging and other NHS arrangements differ across the UK, so check before claiming an exemption.

## If someone regularly cares for you [9]

Your carer may qualify for Carer's Allowance or another form of carer support. In Scotland, check Carer Support Payment. A carer's claim can affect both people's benefits, including some extra disability amounts. Ask for a benefits check for both of you before making a claim.

## Local help, grants and concessions [7, 10]

Ask your council about current help with essential costs, and check Turn2us for charitable grants. There may also be help from energy or water suppliers, or travel concessions with their own eligibility rules. Grants and discounts are not guaranteed, and some schemes change or run out of funding. Ask what is available rather than assuming a disability benefit gives automatic access.

## Ask for a full benefits and financial-support check. One award does not tell you everything you may qualify for.

# Finding help and making a claim

You do not have to understand the whole system before asking for advice.

## Start with a free benefits check [10]

Use a calculator listed at GOV.UK/benefits-calculators, such as Turn2us or entitledto. It gives an estimate, not a guaranteed award. For personal help, contact Citizens Advice or a local welfare-rights service. Have details of household income, savings, housing costs and existing awards ready. Ask for advice before replacing an existing benefit with UC: it can end benefits you already receive.

## Describe what happens in everyday life

Explain the tasks you struggle with, the help or aids you need, and what happens without them. Include how often difficulties occur, how long tasks take, whether you can repeat them and any recovery afterwards. Describe better and worse days accurately. Keep copies of forms, evidence and messages. Ask for help with forms or communication needs if required.

## If you disagree with a decision [11]

A refusal does not judge your worth or mean your condition is not real. Read the decision and get advice promptly. For many DWP decisions, the first step is a mandatory reconsideration, usually within one month of the decision date. Other schemes and nations have different processes. Follow the instructions on your own decision letter; ask for advice even if you have missed a deadline.

## Sources and places to start

[1] GOV.UK: PIP
[2] GOV.UK: UC and health; eligibility
[3] GOV.UK: New Style ESA
[4] GOV.UK: Attendance Allowance
[5] mygov.scot: Adult Disability Payment; Pension Age Disability Payment
[6] GOV.UK: Access to Work; check sick pay with your employer
[7] GOV.UK: Financial help if you’re disabled
[8] NHSBSA: Check help with health costs
[9] GOV.UK: Carer’s Allowance and other benefits
[10] GOV.UK: Benefits calculators
[10] Turn2us: benefits and grants; Citizens Advice: independent advice
[11] GOV.UK: Mandatory reconsideration

Information checked 24 October 2026. General guidance, not an individual entitlement decision. Rules, rates and schemes can change. Use current official guidance and independent advice before acting. Hadamley provides free independent resources.